

OF A KIDNEY DON

For fourteen years, he brazenly broke the law, operated his racket in illegal transplants across four cities and abroad, lived a lavish life and remains unrepentant. Will he ever pay for his crimes?

■ **By Damayanti Datta and Sandeep Unnithan**

Jitne paise chahiye le lo, mujhe chhod do (take as much money as you want, let me go)" —Dr Amit Kumar tried to persuade the Nepal police even as they handcuffed him. Even hours before, Shankar Sainju, the manager of Hotel Wildlife Camp in Chitwan, had no clue about the man who had checked in early on the morning of February 7. Sainju hadn't bothered to read the newspapers, which had splashed pictures of the doctor wanted for running a horrific illegal trade in kidneys in Gurgaon, India. To the hotel manager, Kumar, clad casually in jeans and jacket, looked like any other guest. But room attendant Maheshwar Regmi, who had carried suitcases, coffee and the Kantipur newspaper to room No. 6 on the ground floor, which had been given to Kumar, wondered why the guest looked so restless. When the page with the news item about a kidney racketeer in India was returned slashed, he duly reported the matter to Sainju. At 5 p.m., as the police marched him out, Kumar was still pleading his case: "I have not duped anybody. I am innocent. I just save needy people. I have given life to so many."

That was typical of Kumar: one last-ditch stab at the law he had spent a lifetime bending. The next day, Nepal quickly deported him to India, where

he now faces sustained interrogation by CBI. "Here's an accused felon who jumped bails repeatedly and pretty much went anywhere in the country to run a kidney trafficking agency,"



SCENE OF ACTION: The building in Gurgaon where operations took place

points out criminal lawyer Majid Memon, adding, "This illustrates some of the problems with our existing regulatory structure."

It could have all ended 13 years ago, in August 1994, when Mumbai was shaken by reports of a kidney transplantation racket unearthed by the city

police. The ring had preyed on poor labourers, extracting their kidneys for a price and selling them to wealthy donors. At the headquarters of the Crime Branch in Crawford Market, the then DCP (detection) Rakesh Maria confronted the 38-year-old kingpin, then known as Dr Santosh Rameshwar Raut. The doctor was unrepentant, feeling none of the shame or remorse characteristic of a white collar criminal. "I'm helping the needy," was his reply, the first variation of what would become his alibi down the years. The needy presumably also included the doctor himself.

It was the first time Kumar had been arrested and it would not be the last. Over the next 14 years, he was arrested at least four times in as many states, spending nearly a year in jail. But Kumar (a.k.a. Amit Chaudhary, Amit Purshotam, Rajesh and Suresh Raut) moved steadily from one corner of the country to another and abroad, making big money from the lucrative kidney trade and staying ahead of the law. "There is a streak of criminality in him," says Maria, who is now joint commissioner (crime), Mumbai. "He is a serial offender who won't give up. He knows the loopholes in the law. It will take years to get him convicted. He will hire the best lawyers and continue with this racket. This is the only business he knows," adds the policeman.

At the root of the problem is the federal nature of laws. The Union



1995

Sets up Liberty Hospital in Gurgaon. Flees to Jaipur after a raid. Busted again, goes to Canada.

1999-2003

Returns to Guntur and Gurgaon. In 2003, flees to Canada with wife and child (right) after police register a case in Mumbai.



2007-08

Returns to India in 2007. Racket is busted. Arrested in Nepal and deported to India. Now faces sustained probe by the CBI.